

Android ++, an open source option for Visual Studio

Android developers using Visual Studio have more options now. They can select either Microsoft's cross-platform toolset or an Android development add-on, which has been recently launched as open source.

The open source version of Android++ tool has been launched during the earlier part of January 2016, which permits commercial use. The main feature of Android++ is that it is focused on developers creating Android applications in C/C++ with Android NDK.

According to Justin Webb, the developer of Android++, "Android++ is intended to support applications where performance is paramount—like a game or simulation. It also manages the debugging of those native applications via GDB, which is controllable within the Visual Studio IDE as if you were debugging a Windows application."

Android++ is different from products of its type as it uses MSBuild. Android++ also permits developers to choose for the LLVM/Clang or GCC compilers. It is integrated with the GDB debugger.



Android++ provides better build performance in comparison to Visual Studio 2015. The only major drawback with it is its lack of support for C# or .NET. In such cases, one can use Xamarin or Mono. As of now, there is no pre-built binary available for Visual Studio 2015, but Webb is optimistic and states that it will soon follow.

Android gets 3D functionality from Instagram



3D touch technology came into focus only with smartphones like Apple's iPhone, Huawei's Mate S, etc. Now, Instagram offers this same functionality via an app, which it first launched for iOS in November 2015. After its trial run on iOS, Instagram has introduced it to Android. It has an update that effectively mimics the 3D touch functionality without the actual display technology.

As per research firm IHS, 25 per cent of smartphones in 2016 will come with pressure-sensitive displays. Till date, most Android smartphones do not have this 3D touch function. Instagram wanted to offer this feature to its Android user base as well, so it ported the function to Android devices with a new app update.

The update permits users to press hard and long on a photo to bring up a lightbox-like module. This will give its users a larger preview without abandoning their current screen. One can even 'like' a message and share it. The new update will come up automatically on your Android device with Instagram installed. In case it doesn't, one can download Instagram from the Google Play Store.

Key AI component has been open sourced by Mycroft

The Adapt intent parser converts a user's speech into something that can be understood by an application on a device, including a phone or a desktop. It makes Mycroft work, and has been launched as open source. This means that it is available for anyone to use in their projects. Apart from this, it is a pretty lightweight solution allowing developers to integrate it in their devices with little hardware power. The developers have stated on their website that, "Adapt is lightweight and streamlined, and is designed to run on devices with limited computing resources. Adapt takes in natural language and outputs a data structure that includes the intent, a match probability, and a tagged list of entities. The software was developed at Mycroft AI by a team led by Sean Fitzgerald, formerly one of the developers of both Siri and Amazon Echo."

Python is the programming language behind the Adapt intent parser. This implies that it can be used in anything. It works cross-platform—on Linux, Windows, iOS, as well as Android. It has been released under the GPLv3 licence, permitting anybody to use it.

The Linux Foundation announces 2016 Collaboration Summit

The Linux Foundation has made an announcement regarding its 2016 events. These events provide a common ground for creators, maintainers and practitioners of the world to meet. They allow attendees to view technological trends in the nascent phases and to assist in the evolution of the world's biggest shared technology resources. The events gather the industry's best talent and most influential developers, maintainers and sysadmins to keep a close eye on trends in open source, like Big Data, cloud native applications, containers, IoT, Linux, networking, security, and much more.

According to Jim Zemlin, executive director at The Linux Foundation, "Linux Foundation events are where the world's best technologists meet, collaborate and advance the greatest shared technologies of our time. They are also the place to identify technology trends early, as open source developers and IT managers start projects or advance their ideas during these in-person opportunities."

The Foundation's Collaboration Summit commenced in 2007 and is back this year with better focus on cross-collaboration between open source projects. Apart from tracks focusing on certain project areas, which include open networking, IoT, Big Data and containers, there are also tracks dedicated to topics which